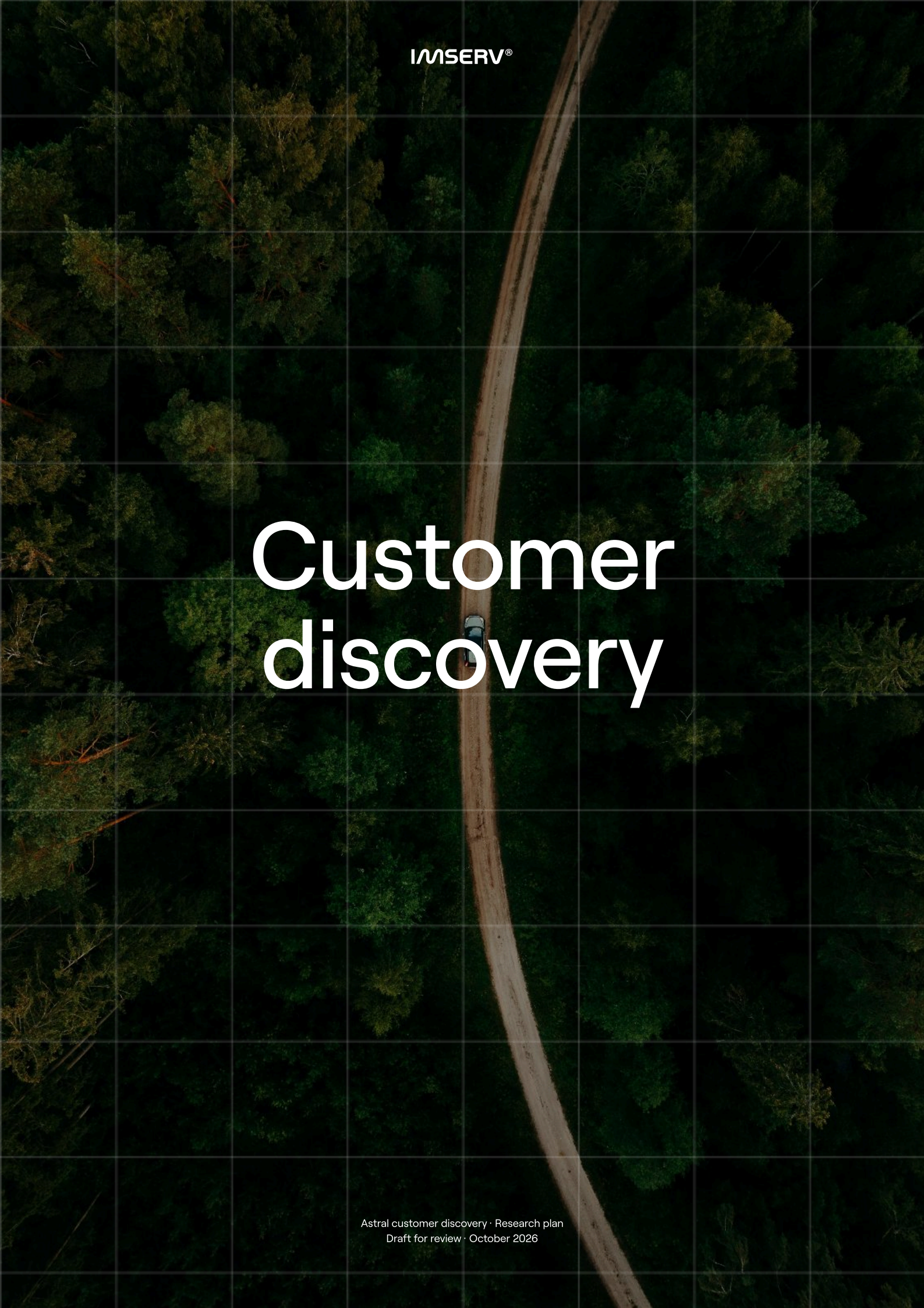
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Customer discovery

Astral customer discovery · Research plan
Draft for review · October 2026

Summary



Summary 04

What we are asking for 05

Background 06–07

Objectives 08

Approach 10

Research activities 11

Schedule 12

Consent and data 13

Risks 14

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Why we are doing this

Summary

We want to run a research-led discovery with IMSERV customers. It should produce three things.

BEHAVIOURAL ARCHETYPES

How people actually work, what they need, and what changes the design.

CUSTOMER JOURNEYS

Evidence-backed. What happens today, including work outside Astral.

PRIORITISED UX DECISIONS

Each one traceable to evidence, and ready for the BA team to turn into stories.

Where this stands

Clive has offered to help unlock customer access. He has **not** agreed a research plan, scope, or sample size. This plan is the proposal for that conversation.

Decision to inform

- Which customer tasks and journeys Astral should prioritise for version one and after.
- Which behavioural differences need different designs, defaults, or trade-offs.
- Where problems sit in the service and process, not the interface. So we do not try to fix ownership or data quality with screen copy.
- What the BA team should specify next, with evidence behind each story.

NOT A FINDING YET

Everything here is a proposed approach. None of it is a finding about IMSERV customers yet.

What we are asking for

Six things we need from reviewers before the research starts.

	Ask	Status
1	**Review this plan** and agree or change the scope, the decisions it supports, and the provisional timeline.	To agree
2	**Agree the first research decisions with Clive.** Which journeys matter most and what is out of scope.	To agree
3	**Name an access coordinator.** Someone who can introduce us to customers and book sessions.	To agree
4	**Access to the people who do the work.** Not only senior account contacts.	To agree
5	**Access to Clive and Emily Haddon's existing customer interview notes.** So we build on them, not repeat them.	To agree
6	**A privacy and data-protection owner.** To agree recording, transcription, storage, and any AI processing before the first session.	To agree

What we already know

Every item has a source and a limit. The research repository has no studies, insights, archetypes, or experience scores yet.

Evidence	Source	Limit
Clive and Emily Haddon did a dozen or more customer interviews. The notes sit with Clive	Work Desk notes, 4 Sep 2026	We have not seen the notes. We do not know who was interviewed or what was asked
British Gas and Scottish Water asked to take part in the beta	Work Desk notes, 4 Sep 2026	A route to customers. Not a sample
Customers want to see their own estate, know meters are working, get invoices and reports, and follow problems. Export is more common than looking at graphs	Max Lake, DataVision walk, 4 Sep 2026	Internal account of customer behaviour. Not observed with customers
People pick sites and meters, compare them, then export a file. They do not browse the whole portfolio	Max Lake, 4 Sep 2026	As above
Company types are Customer, Broker / TPI, Supplier, and Platform admin. A Customer has Energy, Finance, Asset, and Data working hats	IMSERV customer base, desk research, 12 Sep 2026	Public-page desk research. Not a study
Access has three separate parts: what the company bought, the person's role, and which sites and documents they can see	Astral product model, 22 Sep 2026	From the handoff transcript. The role matrix is still open
Large customers narrow from the whole portfolio, to a region, to sites, to one MPAN. One customer has about 8,000 MPANs	As above	Named in a talk. Not observed

Assumed and not yet known

Beliefs we have not tested with customers, and the gaps that matter to the decision.

ASSUMED

- The Energy, Finance, Asset, and Data hats describe how people work. They are a useful recruitment start. They may not be four archetypes.
- Customers mostly use Astral for reporting. Reporting may mean pulling data that is finished somewhere else.
- The people a senior contact introduces us to are the people who do the day-to-day work.
- Problems people raise about the portal are interface problems. Some may be service, process, or data-quality problems.

UNKNOWN

- Who actually logs in today and who just receives a file.
- What starts the work, what people check before they trust a figure, and where the work leaves the portal.
- Who does the work, who approves it, and who receives the result.
- Which behaviour patterns recur across organisations and roles.
- How often those patterns happen across a wider set of customers.
- Where the journey breaks down, and whether the cause is the interface or the service behind it.

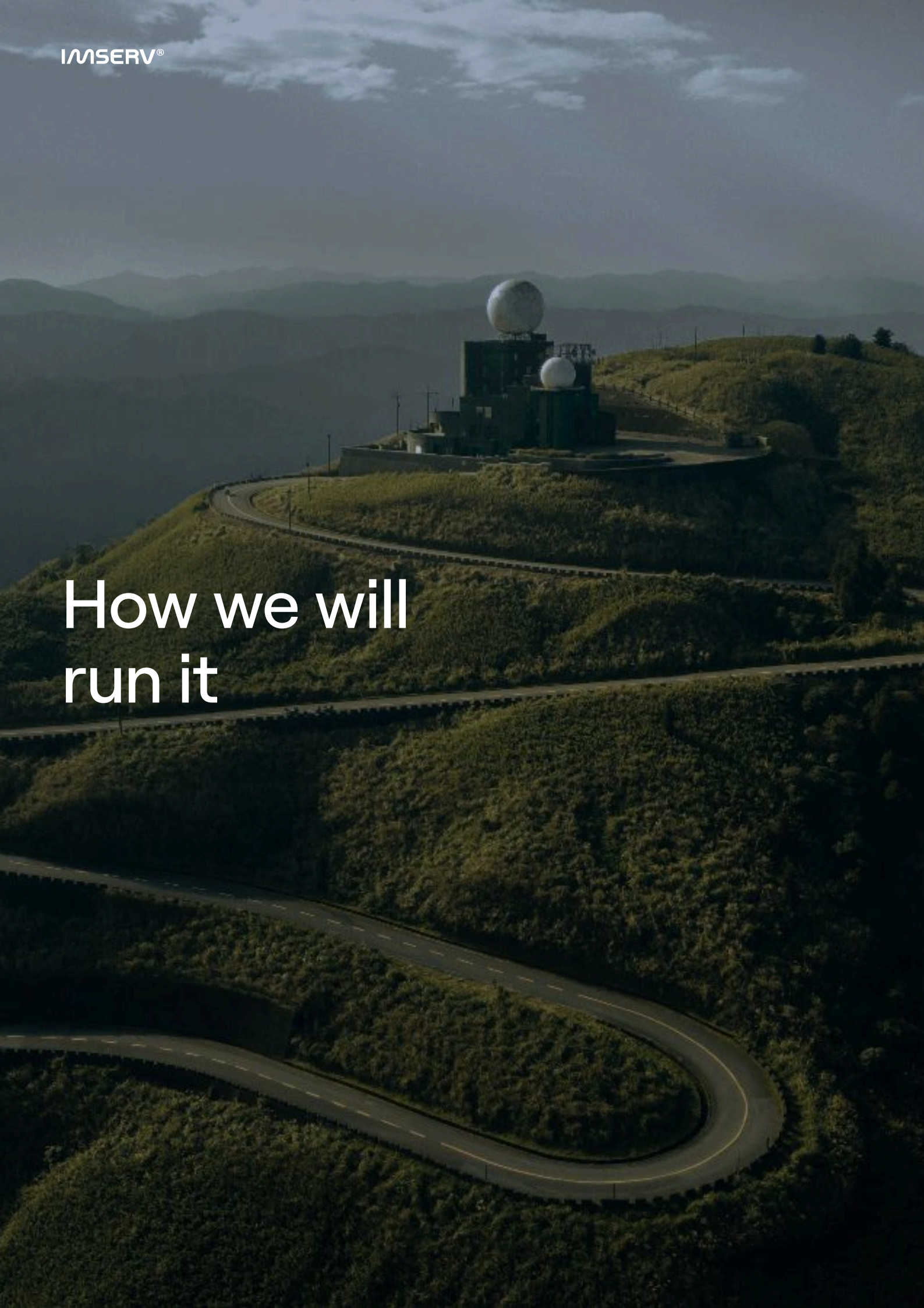
Objectives and questions

PRIMARY RESEARCH QUESTION

How do IMSERV customers do their energy-data work today, and which differences in that work should change how Astral is designed and prioritised?

Objective	Research question	Activity	Evidence	Measure
1. Understand	What triggers the work, and what does finished look like?	Discovery interviews, walkthroughs	Episode accounts, artefacts	Journey stages covered per scenario
2. Identify	Which patterns recur across organisations, roles, and scales?	Rounds 1 and 2, integration	Coded episodes across participants and organisations	Patterns observed in n of N participants and organisations
3. Understand	What do people check before relying on a figure?	Interviews, walkthroughs, survey	Described and shown checks. Reported frequency	Reported frequency among respondents
4. Identify	Who contributes, approves, or acts?	Interviews, walkthroughs	Handoffs, correspondence	Handoffs per journey. Waiting points
5. Determine	Where does it slow down, and why?	Walkthroughs, support evidence, blueprint	Breakdowns traced to cause	Problems classed interface, process, or data
6. Gauge	How often do these patterns happen?	Survey	Responses	Share of respondents, by people and by organisation
7. Evaluate	Do proposed changes meet the need?	Design implication testing	Observed tasks	Task success, effort, confidence

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How we will run it

Review existing evidence → interview and observe → find provisional patterns → survey those patterns → follow up on contradictions → refine archetypes and journeys → test design implications.

Approach

An exploratory sequential mixed-methods discovery. Qualitative research comes first. It sets the concepts and language that the survey then measures.

Connected, not just collected

Interviews build the survey. Survey results guide follow-up recruitment. Both are compared in one analysis (Fetters, Curry and Creswell).

A **short screener** is still used for recruitment. That is different from the main survey.

Archetypes, not decorative personas

We will define research-backed behavioural profiles and customer journeys. The profiles do the job of personas, without fictional biographies.

Archetypes come from recurring patterns. They are not job titles with a new label.

Research activities

Seven connected activities. Each has its own plan with purpose, steps, schedule, safeguards, and output.

ACTIVITY 1

Agree scope and decisions

Agree what the research must help decide, the priority journeys, and what is out of scope.

1 to 2 weeks

ACTIVITY 2

Set up recruitment

Reach the people who actually do the work, across several organisations.

2 to 3 weeks, alongside stage 1

ACTIVITY 3

Discovery round 1

Understand real, recent episodes of work before showing any proposed screens.

2 to 3 weeks, including analysis

ACTIVITY 4

Discovery round 2, targeted

Fill the gaps round 1 found and test our early interpretations.

2 to 3 weeks, including analysis

ACTIVITY 5

Survey

Gauge how often the patterns from discovery happen across a wider group of respondents.

3 to 4 weeks

ACTIVITY 6

Integrate and follow up

Bring the evidence together, investigate disagreement, and refine archetypes and journeys.

About 2 weeks

ACTIVITY 7

Test design implications

Check whether proposed changes address the needs we found.

2 to 3 weeks

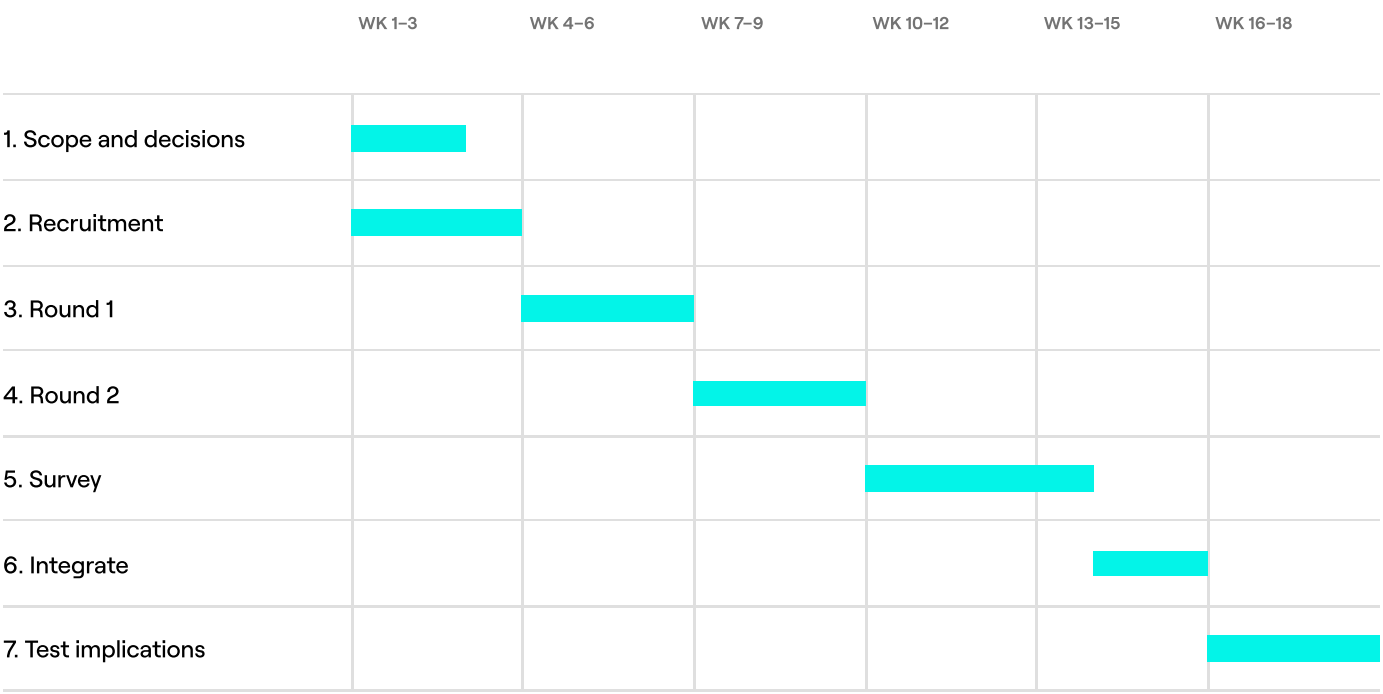
OVERALL

12 to 18 weeks

With overlap, from agreement to tested implications.

Provisional timeline

Estimates to agree, not commitments. Bars show the upper estimate for each stage. With overlap, roughly 12 to 18 weeks from agreement to tested implications.



Stage	Provisional duration	Depends on
1. Agree scope and decisions	1 to 2 weeks	Time with Clive and the manager. Access to existing interview notes
2. Set up recruitment	2 to 3 weeks, alongside stage 1	Access coordinator. Privacy owner sign-off
3. Discovery round 1	2 to 3 weeks, including analysis	Bookings
4. Discovery round 2, targeted	2 to 3 weeks, including analysis	Gap recruitment
5. Survey	3 to 4 weeks	Distribution route. Reachable population known
6. Integrate and follow up	About 2 weeks	Survey results. Follow-up participants
7. Test design implications	2 to 3 weeks	Priority hypotheses. Prototype ready

Neutral draft. No consent wording is sent until it is approved. Legal review before it reaches a participant.

Consent, privacy and data

Agreed with IMSERV's privacy and data-protection owner before the first session.

Every session

- Informed consent for every participant before the session
- Recording, transcription, storage, retention, and any AI processing agreed with IMSERV's privacy and data-protection owner before the first session
- Approved storage with restricted access. Raw recordings and transcripts stay restricted
- Customer documents shown in walkthroughs are redacted or not kept, as agreed
- Participants are P01, P02 in analysis. Removing names alone may not anonymise a distinctive business account
- Quotes in shared outputs only with consent for anonymised quotation
- No consent wording is sent until it is approved. The current wording is a neutral draft

How AI is used

Copilot can help organise approved material, suggest candidate patterns, and keep evidence links up to date. Only within what the privacy owner approves.

It will **not** invent quotes, build archetypes from job titles, or treat simulated customers as evidence.

Risks and limits

What could weaken the evidence, and what we do about it.

Risk	Effect	Mitigation
Introductions only reach senior contacts	We hear about the work, not from the people doing it	Ask for practitioners by the activity they do. Track who does what in the screener
Participants come from one or two organisations	Shared local process looks like a pattern	Track organisation coverage. Recruit across several
Recruitment or privacy approval is slow	The timeline moves	Start both in stage 1. Share early findings from round 1
Existing interview notes are not available	We repeat work, or miss context	Ask Clive early. Record what they cover
The survey reaches only engaged customers	Patterns look more common than they are	Report respondents, not customers. Name the sampling limits
Prototype screens steer discovery	We confirm our own design	No screens until stage 7
Archetypes are expected before evidence exists	A persona deck without support	Agree upfront that archetypes emerge from rounds 1 and 2
Twelve interviews are treated as enough	A multi-role audience is under-covered	Plan rounds, not a total. Keep recruiting while important gaps remain



Thank You

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